

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

IRC Kenya_2022-23_3-month_report_(1)

Fellowship Organization

International Rescue Committee (IRC)

Fellowship City

Nairobi

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/28/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/27/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Grants and Reporting Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Manage grant reporting for IRC Kenya's \$15 Million USD grant portfolio covering health, protection, nutrition, and women's protection and empowerment programs in Kakuma and Dadaab Refugee camps, and urban projects in Nairobi. Ensure project teams adhere to donor (ECHO, BPRM, UNHCR, UNW) obligations relating to reporting requirements, project deliverables, visibility, and partnerships through in person field visits. Support external reporting to ensure timely delivery of high-quality reports including circulating report templates, editing reports, and disseminating drafts for review.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Neutral

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

The previous PiAf fellow in my position, overlapped with my onboarding for 3 weeks. Every week she increased the number of tasks I had that were representative of my workload for when she officially left. She was also available for a week after her official end date. IRC's official orientation took place over the first month and consisted of trainings for each of the programmatic areas as well as logistical training and security briefings. Each training was conducted by the technical coordinator responsible for the programmatic area as well as HR, security, and the grants manager.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

A usual day at work consists of 1 to 2 meetings with the finance team in the morning and the grants team in the evening. Each meeting is usually an hour. In the time in between, there are a number of tasks to do including sending out report templates, checking in on reports that were sent out earlier, contacting field staff to populate reports, updating the grants tracker, and liaising with other refugee agencies through the Refugee Working Group that I am the secretariat for.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Neutral

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

The ECHO reporting period concluded 2 weeks ago and in those last two weeks I assisted the field staff in filling out a 60 page report based on our health, nutrition, and protection program areas. Similarly, I just returned from the field in Kakuma's refugee camp where I was able to meet with UN Women representatives and see the work IRC is doing with increasing women's resilience and knowledge of reproductive rights while decreasing rates of sexual and gender-based violence. I was able to help with that report and we received positive feedback from UNW.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

The office space is beautiful. As far as aesthetics, it is painted black and yellow, the IRC's colors. There are also a number of large paintings on the walls that depict the affected populations we serve as well as large glass boards and cut outs of the names of donors, a map of Africa and Kenya, and global map. There is a large cafe/lunchroom that has an indoor portion and outdoor seating area. It is covered in greenery and floor to ceiling glass windows surround it. There are microwaves, utensils, and group seating. Regarding the official office space, it is arranged in a group-work setting. There are 6 desks in each of 10 open spaces, making 60 desks total. I sit with the grants team and we have

our own space. There are also 6 smaller, sound proof cubicles that smaller teams can meet in. There are also 6 larger, board rooms that large groups meet in. Additionally, each member of the senior management team has their own office space.

To whom do you report?

I report to the Grants Manager as well as the Deputy Director of Grants and Accountability.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

- 1: Visit Kakuma Refugee Camp to assist field staff in completing the State Department Report
- 2: Work on a grant proposal from start to finish
- 3: Complete a report with field staff without assistance from Grants Manager

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?

Yes

Please provide more information on your response above.

N/A

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Irregularly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I traveled to Kakuma Refugee Camp (located in Turkana County) in the middle of November to assist IRC field staff in hosting UN Women and completing the UNW report on increasing women's resilience and protection.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response.

I entered this position with some grant writing experience and more reporting experience, but in a different field with lower stakes. The learning curve for managing such big grants, both in monetary value and complexity, was steep. Sometimes it feels as if my supervisors expect me to know how to complete a report in its entirety, which is not possible because I am not on the ground implementing programs.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my one-way ticket on expedia and traveled from New York's JFK airport directly to Jomo Kenyatta in Nairobi, Kenya. I flew with Kenyan Airways. The ticket cost \$500 USD.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

3 month Business

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Kenyan embassy online portal

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Before

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$50 USD

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I paid

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

We have been trying to get me a special visa pass so that I don't have to continuously keep applying for visas every 2-3 months.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

You should obtain a police clearance from your home state before you leave

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

Yellow Fever - \$300

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

The arrival and the first week were smooth. I arrived on a Sunday and started work on a Monday, which I believe to be the best way to get acclimated to the time difference.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Yes. IRC provides fellows with a guest house. Women stay in one and men in the other. The women's guest house is around the corner from the office.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

I live in Westlands, which is one of the wealthier neighbors in Nairobi. It is also a bit more conservative. The office is located on Riverside, which also host multiple European embassies, UN officers, and other humanitarian organizations.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I walk to work around the corner.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Currently, Nairobi is in its short rainy season, so it rains a few hours of the day and then becomes sunny. It is never oppressively hot. I think the hottest that it's been since I've been here is 80 and the coldest 60.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

IRC Kenya's work attire code is wear what makes you comfortable as long as you're presentable. I go back and forth between from jeans, a hoodie, and gym shoes to a button down and slacks depending on what is happening that day. Outside of work, it depends on the area. Around Westlands where the guest house is, I try to wear more conservative clothing, but there are tons of areas in Nairobi where night life clothes is more than acceptable.

How have you been spending your free time?

In my free time I study Swahili (32 hours a month), go to the malls in the area usually for the bookstores (2x a month), hike at multiple sites around Kenya (1-2x month), and go to the occasional bar/restaurant with the other fellows (4x month). I would highly recommend Nairobi Street Kitchen, Brioche Cafe, Wine and Bottle, Noir Gallery, the Social House, Muse nightclub, Karua Forest hike, Cheche bookstore, Sarit Centre Mall, and Village Market.

Strongly Agree

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Please briefly explain your response below.

I have a partner back in the US, and with the 7/8 hour time difference he is usually waking up when I am finishing my work day; this is the same for my family and friends in NY, DC, and IL. After work, I usually do a round of calls or texts and tell them about my day. My partner and I make time on the weekends to watch movies and cook. As far as a social life in the fellowship post, it is very easy to maintain because the other fellows like to go out!

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes. Both the guest house and work space are well guarded and friendly towards inhabitants. However, petty crime in Nairobi, mainly theft, is common. I have not experienced this, but often foreigners are a target.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I don't display any signs of wealth. For example, I leave my apple watch at home. I also never have my phone out while I am walking and use both straps of my bookbag when walking to work.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have not encountered any criminal attempts. I do want to add a caveat: I am African American and am often mistaken for East African, so I don't think I am always an obvious target.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Theft is common in Westlands, especially towards foreigners. Despite this, it is higher in other areas and would recommend Westlands, Kilimani, and Grigari as areas for safe housing. Another living in the Central Business District.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

A goal I set before orientation was to become proficient in Swahili and more comfortable with the country, especially for the future research that I want to conduct in my PhD program. I am on the way to meeting them!

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

There are several frustrations with my living arrangements. Unfortunately, we get very little notice on when guests will be staying with us. Additionally, there are times when the guest house functions as an extension of the office rather than our living space. Meaning that there are multiple IRC employees with keys to the guest house, including men, who just come into the apartment whenever they have to without notice. Last month we had to request for the guest house to be fumigated because of roaches in the kitchen. Also, the housekeeper is supposed to come 3x a week, but its irregular and often I will wake up to her cleaning extremely early in the morning. There is also a no guest rule for the guest house. The rooms can get pretty cold because the balcony doors have very small gaps underneath them that let air in, but a heater is provided. Overall, I am grateful that we have a place to stay close to the office, but would recommend that either IRC or PiAf provided more funding for fellows to find their own living arrangements.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

N/A

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I think it's important to first recognize that what your experiencing is a culture shock and not you being/feeling unjustly upset or frustrated. The gender dynamics in Kenya are more progressive than other countries I've visited, but not as progressive as what I am used to in the US. This was the biggest culture shock and I've learned to not give up my opinions/right to the way women should be treated, but know when a confrontation is not going to be productive.

Other, "smaller" culture shocks include driving on the left side of the road, the three pronged outlets, everyone is always late for meetings, movies start on time and there are no trailers, and bargaining for produce is common.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I am surprised by how much people assume I'm either Kenyan or Ethiopian; and when I tell them that I'm not they say I have East African ancestors. It's a really entertaining exchange. It happens probably a month.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The most challenging aspect has been getting some of my work colleagues to see me as more than a temporary employee. While it is the truth, it is frustrating when they keep asking our names or don't include us on critical emails.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

Starbucks Iced coffee, soda with high fructose corn syrup, chipotle, salty chips, honey combs cereal, trains

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

The greenery and general nature here is amazing. Secondly, the food taste so much healthier, but I do miss high fructose corn syrup. Majority Black population <3.

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly in USD in my US account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

N/A

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent \$0.00	Utilities \$0.00	Furnishings \$0.00	Phone \$50.00	Home Security \$0.00	Internet \$0.00
Transportation \$40.00	Fitness \$0.00	Entertainment \$0.00	Groceries \$150.00	House Cleaning \$0.00	Eating Out \$75.00
Medications \$0.00	Additional Health Insurance \$0.00	Travel \$0.00	Laundry \$0.00	Other \$260.00	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel) 485.00
Specify "Other" Credit Card and Swahili Class					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I think one of the best things about the orientation was establishing a support group among the other fellows. We are legitimately all friends; all 22 of us. Outside of those relationships, the orientation helped put me in the mindset of getting ready to be uncomfortable for a short period of time before settling in.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

N/A

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Sessions on challenges and how to overcome them.